

'In my experience,' said Lord Caterham, 'people who go about looking for trouble usually find it.' He yawned. 'All the same,' he added, 'I wouldn't mind running up to town myself.'

'Well, come on,' said Bundle. 'But be quick, because I'm in a hurry.'

Lord Caterham, who had begun to rise from his chair, paused.

'Did you say you were in a hurry?' he asked suspiciously.

'In the devil of a hurry,' said Bundle.

'That settles it,' said Lord Caterham. 'I'm not coming. To be driven by you in the Hispano when you're in a hurry—no, it's not fair on any elderly man. I shall stay here.'

'Please yourself,' said Bundle, and withdrew.

Tredwell took her place.

'The vicar, my lord, is most anxious to see you, some unfortunate controversy having arisen about the status of the Boys' Brigade.'

Lord Caterham groaned.

'I rather fancied, my lord, that I had heard you mention at breakfast that you were strolling down to the village this morning to converse with the vicar on the subject.'

'Did you tell him so?' asked Lord Caterham eagerly.

'I did, my lord. He departed, if I may say so, hot-foot. I hope I did right, my lord?'

'Of course you did, Tredwell. You are always right. You couldn't go wrong if you tried.'

Tredwell smiled benignly and withdrew.

Bundle, meanwhile, was sounding the Klaxon impatiently before the lodge gates, while a small child came hastening out with all speed from the lodge, admonishment from her mother following her.

'Make haste, Katie. That be her ladyship in a mortal hurry as always.'

It was indeed characteristic of Bundle to be in a hurry, especially when driving a car. She had skill and nerve and was a good driver; had it been otherwise her reckless pace would have ended in disaster more than once.

It was a crisp October day, with a blue sky and a dazzling sun. The sharp tang of the air brought the blood to Bundle's cheeks and filled her with the zest of living.

She had that morning sent Gerald Wade's unfinished letter to Lorraine Wade at Deane Priory, enclosing a few explanatory lines. The curious impression it had made upon her was somewhat dimmed in the daylight, yet it still struck her as needing explanation. She intended to get hold of Bill Everleigh sometime and extract from him fuller details of the house-party which had ended so tragically. In the meantime, it was a lovely morning and she felt particularly well and the Hispano was running like a dream.

Bundle pressed her foot down on the accelerator and the Hispano responded at once. Mile after mile vanished, traffic stops were few and far between and Bundle had a clear stretch of road in front of her.

And then, without any warning whatever, a man reeled out of the hedge and on to the road right in front of the car. To stop in time was out of the question. With all her might Bundle wrenched at the steering wheel and swerved out to the right. The car was nearly in the ditch—nearly, but not quite. It was a dangerous manoeuvre, but it succeeded. Bundle was almost certain that she had missed the man.

She looked back and felt a sickening sensation in the middle of her anatomy. The car had not passed over the man, but nevertheless it must have struck him in passing. He was lying face downwards on the road, and he lay ominously still.

Bundle jumped out and ran back. She had never yet run over anything more important than a stray hen. The fact that the accident was hardly her fault did not weigh with her at the minute. The man had seemed drunk, but drunk or not, she had killed him. She was quite sure she had killed him. Her heart beat sickeningly in great pounding thumps, sounding right up in her ears.

She knelt down by the prone figure and turned him very gingerly over. He neither groaned nor moaned. He was young, she saw, rather a pleasant-faced young man, well dressed and wearing a small toothbrush moustache.

There was no external mark of injury that she could see, but she was quite positive that he was either dead or dying. His eyelids flickered and the eyes half opened. Piteous eyes, brown and suffering, like a dog's. He seemed to be struggling to speak. Bundle bent right over.

'Yes,' she said. 'Yes?'

There was something he wanted to say, she could see that. Wanted to say badly. And she couldn't help him, couldn't do anything.

At last the words came, a mere sighing breath:

‘*Seven Dials...* tell...’

‘Yes,’ said Bundle again. It was a name he was trying to get out—trying with all his failing strength. ‘Yes. Who am I to tell?’

‘*Tell... Jimmy Theisger...*’ He got it out at last, and then suddenly, his head fell back and his body went limp.

Bundle sat back on her heels, shivering from head to foot. She could never have imagined that anything so awful could have happened to her. He was dead—and she had killed him.

She tried to pull herself together. What must she do now? A doctor—that was her first thought. It was possible—just possible—that the man might only be unconscious, not dead. Her instinct cried out against the possibility, but she forced herself to act upon it. Somehow or other she must get him into the car and take him to the nearest doctor’s. It was a deserted stretch of country road and there was no one to help her.

Bundle, for all her slimness, was strong. She had muscles of whipcord. She brought the Hispano as close as possible, and then, exerting all her strength, she dragged and pulled the inanimate figure into it. It was a horrid business, and one that made her set her teeth, but at last she managed it.

Then she jumped into the driver’s seat and started off. A couple of miles brought her into a small town and on inquiry she was quickly directed to the doctor’s house.

Dr Cassell, a kindly, middle-aged man, was startled to come into his surgery and find a girl there who was evidently on the verge of collapse.

Bundle spoke abruptly.

‘I—I think I’ve killed a man. I ran over him. I brought him along in the car. He’s outside now. I—I was driving too fast, I suppose. I’ve always driven too fast.’

The doctor cast a practised glance over her. He stepped over to a shelf and poured something into a glass. He brought it over to her.

‘Drink this down,’ he said, ‘and you’ll feel better. You’ve had a shock.’

Bundle drank obediently and a tinge of colour came into her pallid face. The doctor nodded approvingly.

Chapter V

The Man in the Road

‘FATHER,’ said Bundle, opening the door of Lord Caterham’s special sanctum and putting her head in, ‘I’m going up to town in the Hispano. I can’t stand the monotony down here any longer.’

‘We only got home yesterday,’ complained Lord Caterham.

‘I know. It seems like a hundred years. I’d forgotten how dull the country could be.’

‘I don’t agree with you,’ said Lord Caterham. ‘It’s peaceful, that’s what it is—peaceful. And extremely comfortable. I appreciate getting back to Tredwell more than I can tell you. That man studies my comfort in the most marvellous manner. Somebody came round only this morning to know if they could hold a tally for girl guides here—’

‘A rally,’ interrupted Bundle.

‘Rally or tally—it’s all the same. Some silly word meaning nothing whatever. But it would have put me in a very awkward position—having to refuse—in fact, I probably shouldn’t have refused. But Tredwell got me out of it. I’ve forgotten what he said—something damned ingenious which couldn’t hurt anybody’s feelings and which knocked the idea on the head absolutely.’

‘Being comfortable isn’t enough for me,’ said Bundle. ‘I want excitement.’

Lord Caterham shuddered.

‘Didn’t we have enough excitement four years ago?’ he demanded plaintively.

‘I’m about ready for some more,’ said Bundle. ‘Not that I expect I shall find any in town. But at any rate I shan’t dislocate my jaw with yawning.’

‘That’s right. Now I want you to sit quietly here. I’ll go out and attend to things. After I’ve made sure there’s nothing to be done for the poor fellow, I’ll come back and we’ll talk about it.’

He was away some time. Bundle watched the clock on the mantelpiece. Five minutes, ten minutes, a quarter of an hour, twenty minutes—would he never come?

Then the door opened and Dr Cassell reappeared. He looked different—Bundle noticed that at once—grimmer and at the same time more alert. There was something else in his manner that she did not quite understand, a suggestion of repressed excitement.

‘Now then, young lady,’ he said, ‘let’s have this out. You ran over this man, you say. Tell me just how the accident happened?’

Bundle explained to the best of her ability. The doctor followed her narrative with keen attention.

‘Just so; the car didn’t pass over his body?’

‘No. In fact, I thought I’d missed him altogether.’

‘He was reeling, you say?’

‘Yes, I thought he was drunk.’

‘And he came from the hedge?’

‘There was a gate just there, I think. He must have come through the gate.’

The doctor nodded, then he leaned back in his chair and removed his pince-nez.

‘I’ve no doubt at all,’ he said, ‘that you’re a very reckless driver, and that you’ll probably run over some poor fellow and do for him one of these days—but you haven’t done it this time.’

‘But—’

‘The car never touched him. *This man was shot.*’

Chapter 4: A Letter

Bundle shook her head. She looked round the room and gave a slight shiver. Supposing Gerry Wade were watching her now. In this room he had died...

She sat very still. The silence was unbroken save for the ticking of her little gold clock. That sounded unnaturally loud and important.

Bundle glanced towards the mantelpiece. A vivid picture rose before her mind's eye. The dead man lying on the bed, and seven clocks ticking on the mantelpiece—ticking loudly, ominously...ticking...ticking...

back with it and had jammed it for the time being. She took a thin paperknife and slipped it into the narrow crack. She was so far successful that a corner of white paper showed. Bundle caught hold of it and drew it out. It was the first sheet of a letter, somewhat crumpled.

It was the date that first caught Bundle's eye. A big flourishing date that leaped out from the paper. Sept. 21st.

'September 21st,' said Bundle slowly. 'Why, surely that was—'
She broke off. Yes, she was sure of it. The 22nd was the day Gerry Wade was found dead. This, then, was a letter he must have been writing on the very evening of the tragedy.

Bundle smoothed it out and read it. It was unfinished.

My Darling Loraine,

I will be down on Wednesday. Am feeling awfully fit and rather pleased with myself all round. It will be heavenly to see you. Look here, do forget what I said about that Seven Dials business. I thought it was going to be more or less of a joke, but it isn't—anything but. I'm sorry I ever said anything about it—it's not the kind of business kids like you ought to be mixed up in. So forget about it, see?

Something else I wanted to tell you—but I'm so sleepy I can't keep my eyes open.

Oh, about Lurcher; I think—

Here the letter broke off.

Bundle sat frowning. Seven Dials. Where was that? Some rather slummy district of London, she fancied. The words Seven Dials reminded her of something else, but for the moment she couldn't think of what. Instead her attention fastened on two phrases. 'Am feeling awfully fit...' and 'I'm so sleepy I can't keep my eyes open.'

That didn't fit in. That didn't fit in at all. For it was that very night that Gerry Wade had taken such a heavy dose of chloral that he never woke again. And if what he had written in that letter was true, why should he have taken it?

Chapter VI

Seven Dials Again

BUNDLE stared at him. And very slowly the world, which for the last three quarters of an hour had been upside down, shifted till it stood once more the right way up. It was quite two minutes before Bundle spoke, but when she did it was no longer the panic-stricken girl but the real Bundle, cool, efficient, and logical.

'How could he be shot?' she said.

'I don't know how he could,' said the doctor dryly. 'But he was. He's got a rifle bullet in him all right. He bled internally, that's why you didn't notice anything.'

Bundle nodded.

'The question is,' the doctor continued, 'Who shot him? You saw nobody about?'

Bundle shook her head.

'It's odd,' said the doctor. 'If it was an accident, you'd expect the fellow who did it would come running to the rescue—unless just possibly he didn't know what he'd done.'

'There was no one about,' said Bundle. 'On the road, that is.'

'It seems to me,' said the doctor, 'that the poor lad must have been running—the bullet got him just as he passed through the gate and he came reeling on to the road in consequence. You didn't hear a shot?'

Bundle shook her head.

'But I probably shouldn't anyway,' she said, 'with the noise of the car.'

'Just so. He didn't say anything before he died?'

'He muttered a few words.'

'Nothing to throw light on the tragedy?'

'No He wanted something—I don't know what—told to a friend of his. Oh! yes, and he mentioned Seven Dials.'

'H'm,' said Doctor Cassell. 'Not a likely neighbourhood for one of his class. Perhaps his assailant came from there. Well, we needn't worry about that now. You can leave it in my hands. I'll notify the police. You must, of course, leave your name and address, as the police are sure to want to question you. In fact, perhaps you'd better come round to the police station with me now. They might say I ought to have detained you.'

They went together in Bundle's car. The police inspector was a slow-speaking man. He was somewhat overawed by Bundle's name and address when she gave it to him, and he took down her statement with great care.

'Lads!' he said. 'That's what it is. Lads practising! Cruel stupid, them young varmintes are. Always loosing off at birds with no consideration for anyone as may be the other side of a hedge.'

The doctor thought it a most unlikely solution, but he realized that the case would soon be in abler hands and it did not seem worth while to make objections.

'Name of deceased?' asked the sergeant, moistening his pencil.

'He had a cardcase on him. He appears to have been a Mr Ronald Devereux, with an address in the Albany.'

Bundle frowned. The name Ronald Devereux awoke some chord of remembrance. She was sure she had heard it before.

It was not until she was half-way back to Chinnings in the car that it came to her. Of course! Ronny Devereux. Bill's friend in the Foreign Office. He and Bill and—yes—Gerald Wade.

As this last realisation came to her, Bundle nearly went into the hedge. First Gerald Wade—then Ronny Devereux. Gerry Wade's death might have been natural—the result of carelessness—but Ronny Devereux's surely bore a more sinister interpretation.

And then Bundle remembered something else. Seven Dials! When the dying man had said it, it had seemed vaguely familiar. Now she knew why. Gerald Wade had mentioned Seven Dials in that last letter of his written to his sister on the night before his death. And that again connected up with something else that escaped her.

Yet that evening, as she sat in front of her bedroom fire, a slim, pyramaeed figure, she found her thoughts reverting to that cheery, vacuous young man, Gerry Wade. Impossible to believe that anyone so full of the joy of living could deliberately have committed suicide. No, the other solution must be the right one. He had taken a sleeping draught and by a pure mistake had swallowed an overdose. That *was* possible. She did not fancy that Gerry Wade had been overburdened in an intellectual capacity.

Her gaze shifted to the mantelpiece and she began thinking about the story of the clocks. Her maid had been full of that, having just been primed by the second housemaid. She had added a detail which apparently Tredwell had not thought worth while retailing to Lord Caterham, but which had piqued Bundle's curiosity.

Seven clocks had been neatly ranged on the mantelpiece; the last and remaining one had been found on the lawn outside, where it had obviously been thrown from the window.

Bundle puzzled over that point now. It seemed such an extraordinarily purposeless thing to do. She could imagine that one of the maids might have tidied the clocks and then, frightened by the inquisition into the matter, have denied doing so. But surely no maid would have thrown a clock into the garden.

Had Gerry Wade done so when its first sharp summons woke him? But no; that again was impossible. Bundle remembered hearing that his death must have taken place in the early hours of the morning, and he would have been in a comatose condition for some time before that.

Bundle frowned. This business of the clocks was curious. She must get hold of Bill Eversleigh. He had been there, she knew.

To think was to act with Bundle. She got up and went over to the writing desk. It was an inlaid affair with a lid that rolled back. Bundle sat down at it, pulled a sheet of notepaper towards her and wrote.

DEAR BILL,—

She paused to pull out the lower part of the desk. It had struck half-way, as she remembered it often did. Bundle tugged at it impatiently but it did not move. She recalled that on a former occasion an envelope had been pushed

'Very like my idea of Mrs Siddons,' he said at last. 'I should think she went in a lot for amateur theatricals. I gather she was very upset about the clock business.'

'What clock business?'

'Tredwell has just been telling me. It seems the house-party had some joke on. They bought a lot of alarm clocks and hid them about this young Wade's room. And then, of course, the poor chap was dead. Which made the whole thing rather beastly.'

Bundle nodded.

'Tredwell told me something else rather odd about the clocks,' continued Lord Caterham, who was now quite enjoying himself. 'It seems that somebody collected them all and put them in a row on the mantelpiece after the poor fellow was dead.'

'Well, why not?' said Bundle.

'I don't see why not myself,' said Lord Caterham. 'But apparently there was some fuss about it. No one would own up to having done it, you see. All the servants were questioned and swore they hadn't touched the beastly things. In fact, it was rather a mystery. And then the coroner asked questions at the inquest, and you know how difficult it is to explain things to people of that class.'

'Perfectly foul,' agreed Bundle.

'Of course,' said Lord Caterham, 'it's very difficult to get the hang of things afterwards. I didn't quite see the point of half the things Tredwell told me. By the way, Bundle, the fellow died in your room.'

Bundle made a grimace.

'Why need people die in my room?' she asked with some indignation.

'That's just what I've been saying,' said Lord Caterham, in triumph. 'Inconsiderate. Everybody's damned inconsiderate nowadays.'

'Not that I mind,' said Bundle valiantly. 'Why should I?'

'I should,' said her father. 'I should mind very much. I should dream things, you know—spectral hands and clanking chains.'

'Well,' said Bundle, 'Great Aunt Louisa died in *your* bed. I wonder you don't see her spook hovering over you.'

'I do sometimes,' said Lord Caterham, shuddering. 'Especially after lobster.' 'Well, thank heavens I'm not superstitious,' declared Bundle.

Thinking all these things over, Bundle had slowed down to such a sober pace that nobody would have recognised her. She drove the car round to the garage and went in search of her father.

Lord Caterham was happily reading a catalogue of a forthcoming sale of rare editions and was immeasurably astonished to see Bundle.

'Even you,' he said, 'can't have been to London and back in this time.'

'I haven't been to London,' said Bundle. 'I ran over a man.'

'What?'

'Only I didn't really. He was shot.'

'How could he have been?'

'I don't know how he could have been, but he was.'

'But why did you shoot him?'

'I didn't shoot him.'

'You shouldn't shoot people,' said Lord Caterham in a tone of mild remonstrance. 'You shouldn't really. I daresay some of them richly deserve it—but all the same it will lead to trouble.'

'I tell you I didn't shoot him.'

'Well, who did?'

'Nobody knows,' said Bundle.

'Nonsense,' said Lord Caterham. 'A man can't be shot and run over without anyone having done it.'

'He wasn't run over,' said Bundle.

'I thought you said he was.'

'I said I thought I had.'

'A tyre burst, I suppose,' said Lord Caterham. 'That does sound like a shot. It says so in detective stories.'

'You really are perfectly impossible, Father. You don't seem to have the brains of a rabbit.'

'Not at all,' said Lord Caterham. 'You come in with a wildly impossible tale about men being run over and shot and I don't know what, and then you expect me to know all about it by magic.'

Bundle sighed wearily.

'Just attend,' she said. 'I'll tell you all about it in words of one syllable.'

'There,' she said when she had concluded. 'Now have you got it?'

‘Of course. I understand perfectly now. I can make allowances for your being a little upset, my dear. I was not far wrong when I remarked to you before starting out that people looking for trouble usually found it. I am thankful,’ finished Lord Caterham with a slight shiver, ‘that I stayed quietly here.’

He picked up the catalogue again.

‘Father, where is Seven Dials?’

‘In the East End somewhere, I fancy. I have frequently observed buses going there—or do I mean Seven Sisters? I have never been there myself, I am thankful to say. Just as well, because I don’t fancy it is the sort of spot I should like. And yet, curiously enough, I seem to have heard of it in some connection just lately.’

‘You don’t know a Jimmy Thesiger, do you?’

Lord Caterham was now engrossed in his catalogue once more. He had made an effort to be intelligent on the subject of Seven Dials. This time he made hardly any effort at all.

‘Thesiger,’ he murmured vaguely. ‘Thesiger. One of the Yorkshire Thesigers?’

‘That’s what I’m asking you. Do attend, Father. This is important.’

Lord Caterham made a desperate effort to look intelligent without really having to give his mind to the matter.

‘There *are* some Yorkshire Thesigers,’ he said earnestly. ‘And unless I am mistaken some Devonshire Thesigers also. Your Great Aunt Selina married a Thesiger.’

‘What good is that to me?’ cried Bundle.

Lord Caterham chuckled.

‘It was very little good to her, if I remember rightly.’

‘You’re impossible,’ said Bundle, rising. ‘I shall have to get hold of Bill.’

‘Do, dear,’ said her father absently as he turned a page. ‘Certainly. By all means. Quite so.’

Bundle rose to her feet with an impatient sigh.

‘I wish I could remember what that letter said,’ she murmured more to herself than aloud. ‘I didn’t read it very carefully. Something about a joke—that the Seven Dials business wasn’t a joke.’

Lord Caterham emerged suddenly from his catalogue.

‘Seven Dials?’ he said. ‘Of course. I’ve got it now.’

‘They had to show some consideration for the sister’s feelings.’

‘Was there a sister? I didn’t know.’

‘Half-sister, I believe. She was much younger. Old Wade ran away with her mother—he was always doing that sort of thing. No woman appealed to him unless she belonged to another man.’

‘I’m glad there’s one bad habit you haven’t got,’ said Bundle.

‘I’ve always led a very respectable God-fearing life,’ said Lord Caterham. ‘It seems extraordinary, considering how little harm I do to anybody, that I can’t be let alone. If only—’

He stopped as Bundle made a sudden excursion through the window.

‘MacDonald,’ called Bundle in a clear, autocratic voice.

The emperor approached. Something that might possibly have been taken for a smile of welcome tried to express itself on his countenance, but the natural gloom of gardeners dispelled it.

‘Your ladyship?’ said MacDonald.

‘How are you?’ said Bundle.

‘I’m no verra grand,’ said MacDonald.

‘I wanted to speak to you about the bowling green. It’s shockingly overgrown. Put someone on to it, will you?’

MacDonald shook his head dubiously.

‘It would mean taking William from the lower border, m’lady.’

‘Damn the lower border,’ said Bundle. ‘Let him start at once. And, MacDonald—’

‘Yes, m’lady?’

‘Let’s have some of those grapes in from the far house. I know it’s the wrong time to cut them because it always is, but I want them all the same. See?’

Bundle re-entered the library.

‘Sorry, Father,’ she said, ‘I wanted to catch MacDonald. Were you speaking?’

‘As a matter of fact I was,’ said Lord Caterham. ‘But it doesn’t matter. What were you saying to MacDonald?’

‘Trying to cure him of thinking he’s God Almighty. But that’s an impossible task. I expect the Cootes have been bad for him. MacDonald wouldn’t care one hoot, or even two hoots for the largest stream-roller that ever was. What’s Lady Coote like?’

Lord Caterham considered the question.